MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS COMMITTEE OF THE WHOLE

Approved 4-17-2024

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

~~Unapproved~~ minutes
April 3, 2024

Meeting was called to order at 9:00 a.m. by Chairman Jeff Haskell.

COMMISSIONERS PRESENT

District 1 Marlene Housler, District 2 Dale Majewski, District 3 Samantha Pitchford, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 6 Jack Kleinhardt, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis and District 8 George Gilmore

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

District 9 Rick Fancon

OTHERS PRESENT

Clerk & Register of Deeds Lori Mott, Administrator Lori Phelps and members of the public

It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the agenda as presented, **motion carried**.

JUSTICE

1. Victims' Rights Advocate Kim Keeley
   Victims' Rights Advocate Keeley informed the Board of Commissioners that April is National Child Abuse Prevention month, Sexual Assault Awareness and Prevention month and National Crime Victims week is at the end of the month and handed out a calendar of events for Clare County in April. She gave a presentation regarding the fundraiser they hold for Crime Victims and explained that the funds are used in Clare County for items such as cell phones without a plan, gas cards, clothing, food, consumers bills and other items that are approved by the State of Michigan to meet the direct needs of crime victims.

2. Animal Control – Rudi Hicks
   Administrator Phelps asked Ms. Hicks to come to the meeting to answer questions regarding tickets. Ms. Hicks confirmed that Assistant Prosecuting Attorney previously instructed her to start writing tickets based on State Law and then Administrator Phelps instructed her to go back to writing tickets based on County Ordinance. Tickets are currently being written based on County Ordinance.

   County Administrator Phelps asked the Board of Commissioners to review the 1989 ordinance and see if anything needs to be updated.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. 24-25 Revenue Preview
   Administrator Phelps confirmed the County Budget is in good shape, but won't be if the Commissioners don't remain pro-active. Decreases in revenue are because of court costs, marijuana crimes have disappeared and criminal reform has crippled the courts in the ability to collect fines and costs. Those two items amount to around $200,000.00. Register of Deeds recording fees and real estate transfer tax will decrease about $125,000.00 because the sale price of property has decreased, which leads to less transfer tax.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

1. 24-25 Revenue Preview - continued
   Jail revenue is also decreasing in the amount of approximately $700,000.00 next year because of the decrease in federal inmates due to criminal reform. The final decrease in revenue that is known right now is about $40,000.00 in interest earned from ARPA Funds that are now spent. The total revenue decrease looks like about $2.5 million.

   Administrator Phelps confirmed that she and the Sheriff are talking with Osceola County and possible combining jails and Clare County would take on Osceola County inmates. Osceola County would then pay Clare County to house their inmates ($35 per day with an average of 55-60 inmates) and Osceola County will pay for those inmates medical costs. She also looked at combining with another county and housing Clare County inmates in a different county. That did not save as much money as Clare County would make by taking on Osceola County inmates.

2. 24-25 Health Insurance Costs Preview
   Each employee currently pays 2% of their insurance. Clare County currently pays $2.5 million for the health insurance plan. Fiscal Year 24-25 Clare County will pay $2.7 million for health insurance.

   Administrator Phelps gave scenarios for how costs would change for the employee and the county:

   a. If Clare County opts into PA152 hard cap the County cost would be $2.1 million and the employee cost would be $966.00 per month for a family plan.
   b. If the employees contributed 5% ($108.00 per month for a family plan) instead of 2% it would cost the County $2.6 million.
   c. If the employees contributed 10% ($216.00 for a family plan) instead of 2% it would cost the County $2.4 million.

   Administrator Phelps discussed other decreases and increases to the revenue. She believes Clare County will see a Headlee Rollback this year, which will decrease tax revenue. The State has promised an increase in revenue sharing in the amount of $400,000.00, if they actually follow through. There is a ballot initiative called Axe the Tax, which would eliminate property taxes all together. Union negotiations are beginning with wage openers for 3 unions and open contracts for 6 unions.

3. Software Purchase – Elections
   County Clerk Mott proposed the purchase of Election Night Reporting software. The current reporting requires you to click on every precinct and add results together to get the final total. The new software would add the results together and show a graph and totals all in one spot for quick and easy results. Clerk Mott confirmed that at the present time there is enough money in the election budget for the purchase.

OPEN DISCUSSION

Administrator Phelps reported to the Board of Commissioners that she had some complaints regarding having MMR run the Emergency Services Brainstorming Meeting. She confirmed that the Clare County Board of Commissioners has no say on what ambulance service comes into the county, the Medical Control Board makes that decision. Administrator Phelps thought that if they all worked collectively as a group and included the current EMS provider, MMR in the discussion, that everyone would have knowledge of the issues and could help to fix the problem. The Clare County Board of Commissioners and Administrator Phelps and only trying to facilitate a meeting to try and fix the problems that exist with the providers in place.

OPEN DISCUSSION - continued

Commissioner Ambrozaitis brought back up the Animal Control issue because the Prosecuting Attorney recently joined the meeting and outlined the conversation that took place earlier in the meeting and asked Prosecutor Ambrozaitis to comment on what the difference is between writing a ticket on a state law vs. county ordinance. Prosecuting Attorney Ambrozaitis explained the process and confirmed that she would be willing to give all information the Board of Commissioners desire if they would just communicate with her office and request the information. She cannot answer questions on the spot in a Board Meeting without researching in advance.

The Board of Commissioners and Administrator Phelps believe the County Ordinance will need to be updated. Possible to mimic State Law.

Meeting adjourned at 10:04 a.m.

Lori Mott, Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

Jeff Haskell, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners